‘Sir,’ I intervened to introduce them to each other, ‘he’s Captain Anshuman Saxena, my elder brother.’ The officer seemed a little surprised as he shifted his gaze from Dada to me, and then back to Dada.

‘So both siblings are here in Kargil?’ an astonished Wing Commander Dhanoa asked. Dada and I nodded. ‘You must have anxious parents back at home.’

It was when he said this that I realized how worried Papaji and Maa would be. It wouldn’t have been easy for them to spend each day knowing that both their kids were participating in the war.

But for Kargil, it was just another sortie, and Dada and I had just come out of the briefing room. Dada insisted on walking me to my helicopter, since I was supposed to return to Srinagar later that day.

‘Were you able to speak to Maa and Papaji?’ he asked.

‘Not since I left Udhampur,’ I said, ‘but I’ve written to them.’

‘And I haven’t been able to find time to do even that,’ Dada said.

‘Do you miss them?’ I asked deliberately, knowing that Dada wouldn’t display any emotions to his younger sister.

‘Don’t *you* miss them?’ Dada asked back, smartly evading the question. But both of us could see the concern. Before I could say anything, I noticed the lines deepening on Dada’s forehead as he seemed to try to listen to something. As did all the other men around us. Within a split second, a faint whistling reached my ears as well.

‘Gunjan, run!’

A frantic Dada pulled me by the arm as he started to run. Everybody had dispersed to either side of the tarmac. Dada dashed inside a bunker, and I followed. Everything happened so quickly that I didn’t have time to understand what was going on. It was when I looked out from the bunker’s loophole that I realized that a missile had landed and exploded just a few metres from my helicopter—the whistling sound was the missile propelling through the air. My ears rang from the explosion. For a while, I couldn’t hear anything but my heartbeat, which was faster than normal. It was at this very moment that I saw fear on Dada’s face. He wasn’t afraid for his life; he